

Early Blues & New Orleans Jazz

Lecture Notes

Evolution of Early Jazz from Blues Vocal Traditions
through New Orleans Jazz and the Rise of the Soloist

Contents

1	Blues Foundations	2
2	Key Technical Concepts	2
2.1	Timbre	2
2.2	Vibrato	2
2.3	Call and Response	2
3	Bessie Smith — “Empress of the Blues”	2
4	Jelly Roll Morton	2
5	W.C. Handy — “Father of the Blues”	3
6	New Orleans Jazz Tradition	3
6.1	Modern Example: Branford Marsalis	3
7	Louis Armstrong — The First Great Soloist	3
7.1	Armstrong’s Complex Legacy	4
7.2	Armstrong & Fitzgerald Recording	4
8	Looking Ahead	4

1 Blues Foundations

- Blues derives from three main chords (I, IV, V) with additional chords often superimposed for harmonic richness
- The **blues scale** is a six-note pentatonic scale plus the flat 5 (tritone), showing connection to West African music
- The tritone was historically called the “Devil’s Interval” due to its dissonant sound; it is central to Western music’s tension-release structure
- **Blue notes**: flat 3, flat 5, flat 7 — the characteristic intervals of the blues
- Standard format is **12-bar blues**, though earlier forms included 8-bar and 16-bar variations
- Recording technology limited early recordings to approximately three minutes per disc side

2 Key Technical Concepts

2.1 Timbre

The quality of sound that distinguishes different musicians and instruments. In jazz, having a unique, identifiable sound is a hallmark of greatness.

2.2 Vibrato

Oscillation or shakiness in sound; a vocal technique that heavily influenced instrumental jazz playing.

2.3 Call and Response

A fundamental structural pattern in blues and jazz. Early jazz features bends, moans, and blue notes in vocal delivery.

3 Bessie Smith — “Empress of the Blues”

- Born 1894 in Tennessee; prominent figure in the early vocal blues tradition
- “**Backwater Blues**” (1927) is an iconic early jazz recording featuring James P. Johnson on piano
- Known for a darker timbre and extensive use of vibrato
- Her vocal techniques became models for instrumental jazz playing

4 Jelly Roll Morton

- Born Ferdinand Morton in 1890 in New Orleans; died 1941. Creole composer and pianist
- Nickname “Jelly Roll” came from playing piano at houses of prostitution
- “**Dead Man Blues**” (1926), recorded with his *Red Hot Peppers*, depicts a New Orleans funeral march
- Music was later criticized for sounding dated, stuck in a 1920s style
- Features clarinet and trumpet solos — clarinet was prominent before the saxophone dominated in the 1930s–40s
- Recording has ragtime influence with stiff rhythm characteristic of early jazz

5 W.C. Handy — “Father of the Blues”

- Pianist and trumpet player; important early composer
- “**St. Louis Blues**” (1922) was one of the first commercial jazz successes
- Featured a “Spanish tinge” (tango rhythm) in the composition
- Recording shows clear switches between swung and straight feel, minor and major tonalities
- Very little improvisation — highly composed
- Notable use of muted trumpet changing the timbre

6 New Orleans Jazz Tradition

- New Orleans is the birthplace of jazz, with instrumentation derived from marching bands
- **Typical ensemble**: trumpet/cornet, clarinet, trombone, banjo/guitar, drums, and tuba (before the upright bass became prominent)
- Features **collective improvisation** — simultaneous melodic lines rather than solo-focused performance
- The “**second line**” **rhythm** comes from the New Orleans funeral tradition: a somber procession followed by a celebration of life
- The traditional New Orleans jazz sound has been preserved to the present day

6.1 Modern Example: Branford Marsalis

- “**Sidney in the House**” (1992) demonstrates a contemporary New Orleans jazz sound
- Features Branford Marsalis on soprano saxophone (paying homage to Sidney Bechet) and Wynton Marsalis on trumpet
- **Sidney Bechet** was important for making the soprano saxophone prominent in jazz before John Coltrane revived it in the 1960s
- Recording features second line rhythm transitioning to a contemporary swing feel
- **Preservation Hall** in New Orleans still performs in the traditional style

7 Louis Armstrong — The First Great Soloist

- Born 1901 in New Orleans; died 1971. Brought improvisation to the forefront as a soloist art form
- Self-taught orphan who aspired to a great sound from his first time playing trumpet
- Started with Joe “King” Oliver’s Creole Jazz Band in 1923; emerged as a soloist with Fletcher Henderson’s band, 1924–1925
- **Invented scat singing in 1926** with “Heebie Jeebies”
- Trumpet playing featured a strident, bright sound with straight tone and vibrato at the end of notes — a highly influential technique
- “**West End Blues**” (1928), from the Hot Five/Hot Seven recordings, is considered the first great improvised jazz solo
- The iconic opening cadenza is one of the most memorable in jazz history
- Nicknames: “Satchmo” and “Pops”

7.1 Armstrong's Complex Legacy

- Was as much entertainer as musician, drawing from the older tradition of minstrelsy
- Minstrel shows were among the most popular entertainment in 1910s–20s America
- Received criticism for a subservient persona, blackface performances, and stage antics
- Counter-argument: opened doors for Black artists as the first prominent crossover figure
- Harlem Renaissance figures called him the “old Negro” vs. Duke Ellington as the “new Negro” — entertainment-focused vs. dignified
- Wynton Marsalis considers Armstrong his hero; Ken Burns's *Jazz* documentary (2000) featured Armstrong prominently
- The documentary was controversial for emphasizing early jazz over modern developments (6–7 episodes on 1900–1950; final episode covering 1965–2000)
- Popular for singing (“What a Wonderful World,” “Hello, Dolly!”) but treasured in jazz for virtuoso trumpet playing

7.2 Armstrong & Fitzgerald Recording

- “**They Can’t Take That Away from Me**” (1955) with Ella Fitzgerald demonstrates high-quality later work
- Shows Armstrong’s trumpet playing and singing voice with better recording fidelity
- Features call and response between vocals and trumpet
- Armstrong’s trumpet playing mirrors his vocal phrasing
- Longer structure than earlier recordings, based on popular song form
- More modern rhythm section with double bass and drums

8 Looking Ahead

Next lecture topics: **Ella Fitzgerald**, **Duke Ellington**, **Count Basie**, and the **Swing Era** of the 1930s.